

Mav and the Fairground Firestorm

The Clovis Valentine's Day Fair was a shimmering sea of neon lights, overpriced teddy bears, and the faint, lingering scent of funnel cake. Maverick walked through the gates, holding the Professor Bucktooth doll by its tail. The beaver was still slightly damp from the dryer and smelled vaguely of "Spring Meadow" laundry sheets and pure, unadulterated judgment.

"Maverick! Scan the perimeter!" the doll squeaked, its button eyes scanning the crowd. "I see a young man with a giant purple gorilla but zero carnations! This is a structural catastrophe! The gorilla has no floral counter-balance!"

"Professor, can we please just play one game of Skee-Ball and go home?" Mav pleaded.

"Justice never sleeps, and neither does a high-quality polyester blend!" Bucktooth shouted.

The next hour was a blur of chaos. At the **Ferris Wheel**, the Professor managed to jam a cotton candy stick into the gears, stopping a couple at the very top. He then used Mav's phone to megaphone a lecture about how their relationship lacked "proper scaffolding."

At the **Tunnel of Love**, the Professor leaped from Mav's arms and dove into a passing boat like a fuzzy, sticky commando. "CITIZEN! Why is your date's hand empty? If you cannot provide a bouquet, you shall provide a formal apology for your romantic negligence!" he yelled, slapping a man with a wet churro.

By the time they reached the midway, Mav had counted at least ten ruined dates. "Professor, we have to go. People are starting to point, and not in the 'Oh, look at that cute toy' kind of way. More in the 'I'm going to throw that kid into the duck pond' kind of way."

"One more, Maverick! Look! A foundational crisis in the making!"

Leaning against the "Test Your Strength" bell was a couple that looked like they had been teleported directly from a 1954 high school prom. He wore high-waisted slacks and a pocket protector; she wore cat-eye glasses and a polka-dot dress. They were both staring at their shoes in agonizing, nerdy silence.

"Observe the lack of momentum," Bucktooth whispered. "The social friction is too high. I must lubricate this situation with **Beaver Logic**."

The doll scuttled over and hid behind a trash can near the boy. "Psst! Kid! Tell her her spectacles have the load-bearing capacity of a diamond-encrusted suspension bridge!"

The boy jumped, looking around. "Who said that?"

"Tell her," the doll hissed, "that her presence is the only thing preventing a total seismic collapse of your heart! Also, give her this!"

With a blur of fuzzy paws, the Professor "borrowed" a heart-shaped box of chocolates from a nearby prize booth and shoved it into the boy's hands.

The boy, terrified and confused, blurted out the lines. "Mildred... your glasses are... very structurally sound? And here is some chocolate I definitely didn't just find behind a trash can."

Mildred let out a snort-laugh that sounded like a joyful trumpet. "Oh, Harold! You're so weirdly poetic!" She grabbed his hand, and they skipped off toward the carousel, Harold looking like he had just survived a lightning strike.

Mav picked up the Professor. "I don't understand how your brain works, but somehow, you fixed them."

"It's all about the tension and compression, Maverick," the doll squeaked proudly.

Just then, Mav looked toward the Ferris Wheel. A crowd of about thirty angry boyfriends and husbands had gathered. They were holding burning torches (which they had made out of extra-long corndog sticks and napkins) and actual pitchforks from the "Petting Zoo" exhibit.

"There he is! The kid with the judgmental plushie! He told my wife my love was 'hollow-core'!" one man roared.

"And he stole my syrup this morning!" another yelled.

Mav tucked the Professor under his arm. "Uh, Professor? Remember how you said you were a 'structural miracle'?"

"I did!"

"Well, right now, we need a 'structural retreat!'"

"AHA! Tactical evacuation!" the doll shrieked. "TO THE MUSTANG, MAVERICK! TO THE MUSTANG! TODALOO, YOU ROMANTIC AMATEURS!"

Mav sprinted toward the parking lot as a wave of angry, dateless men chased them through the fairgrounds, their corndog torches flickering in the night.